A FAMILY SERVICE HISTORY

Cyril Roy Phillips

SX8216 · Second Australian Imperial Force



Enlistment photograph, Adelaide, 1940 · NAA B883, SX8216, p. 4 (digitally colourised; colours other than the recorded hair and eyes are interpretation)

Egypt · Libya · Palestine · Transjordan · Syria/Lebanon · Ceylon · Papua

Fact-checked edition · November 2026

In memory of a South Australian blacksmith who served as a mobile army craftsman across the Middle East and the Pacific, 1940–1944.

FOREWORD

A blacksmith from the Mallee

Cyril Roy Phillips was born at Port Broughton, South Australia, on 9 August 1917. In 1940 he was a 22-year-old, single, Methodist blacksmith living at Lowaldie in the Murray Mallee. His mother, Mildred Maud Phillips, was recorded as his next of kin. The Army described him as having brown hair and blue eyes.

He enlisted at Adelaide on 6 July 1940 as Private SX8216. His trade was recorded as Group I Blacksmith, and he joined the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops. These mobile engineering units recovered and repaired vehicles, tanks, guns and other equipment so that fighting formations could keep operating far from permanent workshops.

Cyril served in Egypt and Libya, including the siege of Tobruk; then Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon; Ceylon; and Papua. A 1971 letter by fellow serviceman Bert Evans (SX4626) identifies him as a member of 6 Australian Recovery Section, 2/2nd Army Field Workshops, and recalls his blacksmithing after Bardia, spring repairs at Mersa Matruh and service inside Tobruk during the siege. The letter opens by saying that Cyril himself had asked Evans to record and verify these events.

After fourteen months in Papua, Cyril was evacuated to Australia in February 1944. His record gives essential hypertension as the diagnosis during his return and the medical boards that followed. He married Irene May on 25 March 1944 (Irene May are her given names; her surname before marriage is not yet confirmed) and was discharged medically unfit at Wayville on 28 November 1944. He died on 7 January 1977, aged 59, and was buried at Dudley Park Cemetery on 11 January.

How to read this history

Personal facts come first from Cyril's own service record. Unit war diaries and routine orders are identified separately from general unit movements. Bert Evans's 1971 letter is retrospective first-hand testimony. Where a conclusion is probable but not proven, the text says so, and unit locations are not automatically treated as proof of Cyril's exact location. Gold-bordered boxes mark findings added in this fact-checked edition; a full list of changes is at the back.

At a glance

Born	9 August 1917 · Port Broughton, SA
Enlisted	6 July 1940 · Adelaide · SX8216
Rank	Private; Craftsman (Cfn) after the workshops passed to the new AEME corps in December 1942. Craftsman was the AEME equivalent of private, not a promotion.
Trade	Group I Blacksmith; re-graded Group I Fitter (written "Ins") on 1 February 1944
Principal units	2/2nd Army Field Workshops (6 Australian Recovery Section); 6 Australian Division Ordnance Workshop (16 Brigade Section); 2/121 Australian Brigade Workshops; later 7 Technical Maintenance Section
Overseas service	Middle East 1940–42 · Ceylon 1942 · Papua 1942–44 · 1,129 days in all
Marriage	Irene May · 25 March 1944 · she became his next of kin on 28 April 1944
Discharged	28 November 1944 · Wayville · medically unfit · 1,607 days' total service
Recorded medals	1939–45 Star; Africa Star; Pacific Star; Defence Medal; War Medal 1939–45; Australia Service Medal 1939–45
Died	7 January 1977 · aged 59 · buried Dudley Park Cemetery, Adelaide, 11 January 1977

THE PHOTOGRAPH

Private Phillips, 1940



Cyril Roy Phillips, SX8216, from the attestation papers. The original is in his National Archives of Australia service file, B883, item 6411180, page 4.

The original file also contains front and profile views. The service record gives his hair as brown and his eyes as blue. The colourised version should stay labelled as an interpretation: the recorded hair and eye colours are documentary, while skin and uniform tones are not independently verifiable.

The Service and Casualty Form lists his distinguishing marks as a small cyst behind and below the left ear, two scars on both knees, a birthmark on the left shoulder and a scar on the back of the head. These are identifying details from the form, not features to read into the photograph.

A further image appears on Cyril's Virtual War Memorial Australia profile. Its visible caption does not give enough provenance to confirm it is Cyril, so it is not reproduced here as a confirmed portrait.

His family in the records

- **Mother:** Mildred Maud Phillips, first recorded at Lowaldie. By September 1943 she was at Borrika, writing to the Army for the badge issued to the female relatives of men serving overseas (see the appendix).
- **Wife:** Irene May Phillips, married 25 March 1944. The form was amended on 28 April 1944 to make her next of kin, with Borrika as her address. In 1977 she was living at Mile End.
- **Irene's surname before marriage:** a published family-tree lead suggests Dohnt. Searches for this edition found no civil record confirming it, so it is not printed as fact.

Early-life places

Port Broughton: birthplace, on the eastern shore of Spencer Gulf. **Lowaldie:** home and blacksmith's occupation at enlistment, in the Karoonda East Murray district. **Borrika:** later family address in the same Murray Mallee district, including the address used for medal dispatch in 1954.

Enlistment, training and the voyage

Cyril's medical examination took place in Adelaide on 25 June 1940, and he was assessed fit for Class I service. He enlisted and was sworn in on 6 July, recorded as a blacksmith from Lowaldie and graded Group I Blacksmith. He reported to the Recruit Reception Depot on 9 July and marched into the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops on 16 July.

He took pre-embarkation leave from 11 to 19 August. His record says he entrained for Melbourne on 14 September and embarked on 15 September. His mother's 1943 letter says he "sailed on the 14th Sept 1940"; she was probably remembering the day he left South Australia.

Brigadier G.H.S. Moran's unit history identifies the transport as the Dutch liner *Nieuw Holland*. The service record gives 12 October 1940 as his Middle East disembarkation date, at a place read as Kantara, the Suez Canal railhead through which troops passed on their way to camps in Palestine and Egypt.

New in this edition

The Naval Historical Society of Australia records that convoy US 5 sailed from Fremantle on 22 September 1940 with four Dutch liners, *Christiaan Huygens*, *Indrapoera*, *Nieuw Holland* and *Slamat*, carrying 4,262 troops, escorted by HMAS *Canberra* as far as 2 October. Cyril therefore boarded at Melbourne on 15 September, called at Fremantle, and sailed with the convoy from there.

The Department of Veterans' Affairs order of battle records an earlier echelon of the 2/2nd Field Workshops leaving Melbourne on 13 August 1940 and travelling via Bombay, also reaching the Middle East on 12 October. Because Cyril was on leave until 19 August, he cannot have been in that party. The unit evidently travelled in two groups, and Moran's statement that the South Australian sections joined the Main Shop at Melbourne should be checked against the war diary.



Helwan, Egypt, late 1940. Men of the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops with the unit's mobile machine-shop 'L' trailer. AWM 004227; photograph by Frank Hurley.

The 2/2nd Army Field Workshops

The unit had a Main Shop, including general engineering, transport and instrument sections, and three Recovery Sections: Nos. 4, 5 and 6. The Main Shop and No. 4 were raised in Victoria; Nos. 5 and 6 were raised in South Australia and trained at Woodside Camp in the Adelaide Hills. The war diary records a visit to Nos. 5 and 6 on 16 August 1940, when most personnel were on pre-embarkation leave.

Now established

Evans's 1971 letter identifies Cyril as "SX 8216 Cfn C R Phillips of 6 Aust Recovery Section", and says Evans served with him from June 1940 until September 1942. This direct identification replaces the earlier booklet's estimate that Cyril was "80% likely" to belong to one of the two South Australian sections.

Egypt and Libya: the first desert campaign

From Helwan, near Cairo, the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops moved into the Western Desert in December 1940 as the British and Commonwealth offensive drove the Italian Tenth Army out of Egypt. Recovery parties retrieved broken-down, bogged, damaged and captured equipment; workshop teams repaired vehicles, guns and machinery close to the front.

The unit diary records the Main Shop and No. 6 Recovery Section moving to Amiriya on 5 December and Fuka on 16 December. An advance party of No. 6 Recovery Section was at Kilo 104 near Sidi Barrani from 23 December, so we cannot say exactly where Cyril spent Christmas.



Fuka, Egypt, December 1940. The 2/2nd Field Workshops cookhouse decorated for Christmas. AWM P01522.003.

Bardia, captured tanks and the work of a blacksmith

The 6th Australian Division attacked Bardia on 3 January 1941; the town fell on 4 January and the last Italian positions surrendered on 5 January. Evans recalled Cyril, working as a blacksmith, putting in extremely long hours with other men to make damaged British and Italian tanks serviceable for the assault on Tobruk. Evans cited page 19 of the 1941 publication *Active Service (with Australia in the Middle East)*, which credited an Australian Army Field Workshop with a large part in getting these tanks into condition.

New in this edition

This work can now be linked to a well-documented episode. Italian tanks captured at Bardia were issued to A Squadron of the 6th Division Cavalry Regiment, which painted large white kangaroos on their hulls and turrets so they would not be mistaken for enemy vehicles. They went into action around Tobruk, which the 6th Division captured on 21–22 January 1941. The tanks Cyril helped make serviceable were very probably among these.

Evans also names the places where the section kept 6th Division vehicles running: before and in Tobruk, then at Derna, "Sholta" (almost certainly Slonta), Barce and Maddalena.

One South Australian of the same unit was decorated for this campaign: Private Ernest Oswald James Dunning, SX9731, 2/2 Field Workshops, received the Military Medal, gazetted on 8 July 1941. His SX number suggests he served in one of the two South Australian recovery sections, but his section is not yet confirmed.



Maddalena, Cyrenaica, February 1941. The 2/2nd Army Field Workshops camp. AWM 006532; photograph by Frank Hurley.

Mersa Matruh: 140 sets of springs

In March 1941, as the 6th Australian Division was withdrawn from the Western Desert for service in Greece, the unit was at Mersa Matruh repairing and servicing the division's vehicles. Evans, the unit's R&I clerk responsible for logging repair details, stated that Cyril and his section "set up" 140 sets of vehicle springs, working almost non-stop. This is unusually specific testimony: it identifies the type and scale of Cyril's work, and explains why a blacksmith mattered to a mobile division.

Why the spring work mattered

A vehicle spring was a critical part of a truck's suspension. On desert tracks, broken or fatigued springs could take a vehicle out of service even when its engine was sound. A field blacksmith could heat, re-set, temper and refit spring leaves without sending the vehicle back to a base depot. Setting up 140 sets meant rebuilding the running gear of a large part of a division's transport.

The unit diary records 432 jobs for No. 6 Recovery Section at Mersa Matruh in February–March 1941. The diary establishes the section's workload; Evans connects Cyril personally to the spring repairs. Cyril's service record has no casualty or posting entry between October 1940 and June 1941, which is consistent with continuous service in the unit but does not rule out short unrecorded detachments.

Evidence note: Evans wrote in February 1971, about 30 years after the events. Exact figures such as the 140 spring sets should remain attributed to his recollection unless a workshop repair ledger is found.

Tobruk: the siege and the windmill

In early March 1941 the newly arrived 9th Australian Division began relieving the 6th Division in Cyrenaica so that the 6th could go to Greece. When German and Italian forces under Rommel struck at the end of March, the 9th Division fell back and reached Tobruk on 9 April. Axis forces cut the landward approaches on 10–11 April, and the Australian War Memorial dates the siege from then. The 9th Division and the 7th Division's 18th Brigade formed the core of the garrison; most Australians were relieved by sea between August and October, and the siege was lifted by Operation Crusader in late 1941.

Evans says that within a week of returning to Alexandria from Mersa Matruh the unit was ordered back to the Western Desert with the 9th Division, and re-entered Tobruk a few hours before it was invested. No. 6 Recovery Section, under Captain J.W. Redpath, was the 2/2nd's element sent there. The 2/1st Army Field Workshops diary records the section moving to a position on the Derna Road about one mile west of Tobruk on 11 April. Moran calls the site "the windmill"; it has not yet been matched to a feature on a contemporary map.

Evans recalls that Cyril and the others worked from daylight until dark maintaining the garrison's vehicles, living in dugouts under frequent air raids, and that Cyril often helped him, as orderly room sergeant, collect rations, supplies and mail from the town.

Historical conclusion

Cyril's membership of 6 Recovery Section and his presence in Tobruk during the siege are supported by a named comrade's first-hand account, by the unit chronology, by his own hospital entry inside the fortress, and by the Rats of Tobruk Association register, which lists him by name and number.

Cyril's record shows admission to "4 Aust Gen Hosp" on 14 June 1941 with influenza, discharge on 17 June with enteritis, and return to his unit the same day. The 2/4th Australian General Hospital served inside Tobruk during the siege.



Tobruk, 1941. View across the Derna Road from Post S17 near the western perimeter. AWM 128987.

Leaving Tobruk: the destroyer "Stewart"

Evans recalls a night embarkation from Tobruk in an RAN destroyer he names as "Stewart", followed by a rail journey to Alexandria during which the train was strafed by enemy fighters, with men killed. The ship intended is almost certainly HMAS *Stuart*, leader of the "Scrap Iron Flotilla": the Sea Power Centre history records that she joined the Tobruk Ferry Service in June 1941 and made 24 runs in June and July before her final Tobruk run on 25–26 July.

New in this edition

The evacuation can be dated more tightly than "mid-July". Cyril was back with his unit inside Tobruk on 17 June, and the unit diary has No. 6 Recovery Section marching in to Barbara, Palestine, on 11 July. The section therefore left Tobruk between 17 June and about the first week of July. That window sits squarely inside *Stuart's* run of 24 ferry trips, which makes her a strong candidate, though still not proven. The "mid-July" date is a note on the letter transcript and conflicts with the diary.

The rail journey also tells us something. A destroyer from Tobruk normally landed troops at Alexandria or Mersa Matruh; a train "to Alex" suggests the section was landed at Mersa Matruh, the forward railhead, and went on by rail.

Evans's "nearly four months" is generous: from the section's arrival in early April to departure by early July is about three months. This is a normal memory effect after 30 years, not a reason to doubt the substance of his account.

Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon

After leaving Tobruk, No. 6 Recovery Section rejoined the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops in Palestine. The unit supported Allied formations across a wide area, including vehicle maintenance for forces moving towards Iraq.

The unit diary records No. 6 Recovery Section reaching Barbara, near Ascalon (modern Ashkelon), on 11 July 1941. The unit later moved through Beit Jirja and Khassa. From late August into September the section serviced the 5th Indian Division at pumping station H4 on the oil-pipeline route in Transjordan. In October the workshops moved to Ablah in the Bekaa Valley of Lebanon, between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon ranges, where Moran describes frozen and cracked engine blocks being welded in the winter.

Evans remembered the unit "keeping Indian vehicle convoys moving on their journey to Iraq to quell the insurrection there". The Iraqi revolt had in fact ended in May 1941, before the section left Tobruk, so the convoys of August–September 1941 belonged to the later build-up of British and Indian forces in Iraq and Persia. Evans also lists Syria before Transjordan; the diary order (Palestine, Transjordan, then Lebanon) is preferred.

Cyril is named in the unit's Routine Orders, which explicitly identify him:

- **22 September 1941, Khassa:** the guard roster for 23 September includes "SX8216 Phillips, C.R." with 6 Recovery Section.
- **29 September 1941, Khassa:** the guard roster again includes Phillips, C.R., with HQ and 6 Recovery Sections.
- **29 October 1941, Ablah:** Phillips C.R. appears on the guard roster for 30 October; the duty section is recorded as MT Section.
- **6 November 1941, Ablah:** the guard includes SX8216 Phillips C.R.; the duty section is HQ and 6 Australian Recovery Section.

One roster places him on an MT Section duty, a reminder that men could be detailed for duties outside their own section.



Ablah, Lebanon (then usually described in Australian records as Syria), November 1941. Men of the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops overhauling a 25-pounder. AWM 021687.

The unit left Syria on 27 January 1942 and reached Port Said on 20 February. Cyril's service record shows embarkation in the Middle East on 12 March 1942 and disembarkation in Ceylon on 27 March.

CHAPTER FIVE · MARCH – NOVEMBER 1942

Ceylon, home and a reorganised army

With Japan now at war, the 6th and 7th Australian Divisions were recalled from the Middle East. On the voyage home the 6th Division's 16th and 17th Brigades were landed in Ceylon as an interim garrison against a feared Japanese invasion. The 2/2nd Army Field Workshops reached Colombo on 27 March 1942; Moran gives the camp name as "Maddagedera". The workshops became an engineering centre for the force, working in intense heat and heavy rain. Japanese carrier aircraft raided Colombo on Easter Sunday, 5 April 1942, only nine days after the unit landed.

Cyril's record shows that he sailed for Australia aboard HMT *Ekma* on 13 July 1942 and disembarked at Melbourne on 7 August. The typed discharge summary and unit diary support 7 August where a handwritten date could be misread. He took leave from 13 August to 6 September.

New finding

The 16th/17th Brigade question raised in the previous edition can be partly answered from shipping dates. Units of the **16th Brigade**, such as the 2/1st Battalion, left Ceylon on 13 July 1942 and disembarked at Melbourne on **7 August**, the same dates as in Cyril's record. Units of the **17th Brigade**, such as the 2/5th Battalion (on *Athlone Castle*) and the 2/3rd Field Hygiene Section, arrived on **4 August**. Whatever the unit's arrangements in Ceylon, Cyril came home with the 16th Brigade group. That fits his later posting to the 16 Brigade Section of the divisional workshop, and suggests Evans's "17th Brigade" refers to the outward attachment or is a slip of memory.

On 15 September 1942 Cyril was transferred to the 6 Australian Division Ordnance Workshop at Greta, New South Wales. The 2/2nd's diary records the workshop being reorganised into an Army Ordnance Workshop and a Divisional Ordnance Workshop with headquarters and two brigade group workshops. On the same date No. 1 Group moved from Minimbah to Greta. Cyril may have been in No. 1 Group, but the diary evidence does not prove it.

On 1 December 1942 the workshop units passed from the Australian Army Ordnance Corps to the newly formed Australian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers (AEME). That is why Cyril's rank becomes Craftsman (Cfn) in later papers: it was the AEME title for a private soldier, not a promotion.

Do not confuse "No. 1 Group" and "No. 2 Group" (workshop sub-units) with Cyril's "Group I" trade grading (a classification of his skilled trade).

Papua

Cyril embarked at Townsville aboard *Duntroon* on 8 December 1942 and disembarked in New Guinea on 12 December. The Papuan campaign was not over: Gona had fallen on 9 December, but Buna held out until 2 January 1943 and Sanananda until 22 January. Cyril arrived during the closing phase of the beachhead battles.

His service record places him with the 16 Brigade Section of the 6 Australian Division Workshop on arrival. The 16th Brigade itself had fought along the Kokoda Track and at Sanananda and was flown back to Port Moresby, depleted by disease and casualties, before returning to Australia in January 1943. Cyril stayed on: on 12 July 1943 he was taken on strength by 2/121 Australian Brigade Workshops, from "16 Bde Sec 6 Aust Div W/S". In a letter dated 6 September 1943 his mother addressed him as "Cfn C.R. Phillips, 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops A.E.M.E."

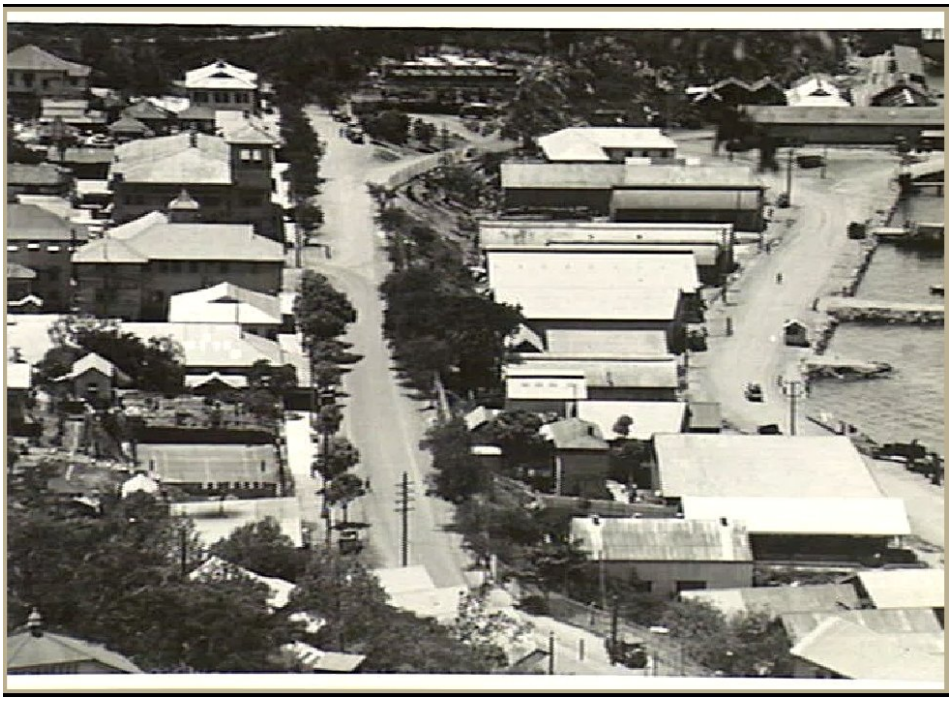
The strongest geographical conclusion is that Cyril served in the Port Moresby base area. He was admitted to 128 Australian General Hospital there in September 1943; he was admitted to 2/1 Australian General Hospital, then at Bootless Bay outside Port Moresby, in January 1944; the 2/121 Brigade Ordnance Field Park diary lists 2/121 Brigade Workshops among units it supplied; and he embarked on the hospital ship *Manunda* at Port Moresby in February 1944. This evidence does not fix the exact workshop camp or exclude short detachments.

Verified

Both hospitals check out. The 128th AGH grew from the Port Moresby base hospital formed in April 1941 and served there until August 1944. The 2/1st AGH set up a 1,200-bed hospital at Bootless Bay in September 1943 and was there in January 1944, as Cyril's record implies.



Hospital Ship Manunda, 1944. AWM 075198. Cyril was evacuated from Port Moresby aboard Manunda in February 1944.



Port Moresby, 29 December 1943. Looking up Port Road towards the naval workshops. AWM 062135.

Illness and regrading

Cyril was admitted to 128 AGH from 5 to 23 September 1943 with "NYD" (not yet diagnosed), then passed through the New Guinea Details Depot before returning to his unit. On 29 January 1944 he was admitted to 2/1 AGH at Bootless Bay for investigation. On 1 February he was regraded from Group I Blacksmith to Group I Fitter; the specialty after "Fitter" is written "Ins". "Instrument" is plausible in a workshop context but unconfirmed. On 13 February 1944 he embarked at Port Moresby aboard *Manunda* for Australia.

What the Port Moresby evidence does not prove

It does not prove that Cyril never went elsewhere in New Guinea, that his workshop stood inside Port Moresby township, or that all of 2/121 Brigade Workshops was based there. The 16 Brigade Section and 2/121 Brigade Workshops war diaries have not yet been located. The safest wording remains "Port Moresby area, strongly indicated by the available records".

Home, discharge and later life

Cyril reached Brisbane on 17 February 1944. He travelled by No. 2 Australian Ambulance Train to 115 Australian General Hospital at Heidelberg, Victoria, where essential hypertension was diagnosed on 19 February. On 22 February he was transferred to 121 Australian General Hospital at Northfield, South Australia, which had moved there from Katherine in August 1943 and occupied the Morris Hospital site.

A medical board on 8–10 March graded him Class B, and he was posted to the South Australian Lines of Communication Area Details Depot. He married Irene May on 25 March 1944. From 26 April to 26 May he was attached to the SA L of C Area Workshops, AEME. In June he went to Queensland and was posted to 7 Technical Maintenance Section, attached to Advanced LHQ Signals, and attended Linemen Mechanics Course No. 70 at 1 Australian Training Depot from 24 June to 3 July.

His medical class became Temporary D on 21 August. He returned to Adelaide for discharge on 25 September, spent 2–18 October at 105 Australian Military Hospital, and was graded Class D by the final medical board on 17 October. He was discharged medically unfit at Wayville on 28 November 1944.

Service days: the arithmetic resolved

The record gives total service as 1,607 days and overseas service as 1,129 days. Both figures are exact when each period is counted inclusively, which was Army practice:

Period	Dates (inclusive)	Days
Total service	6 July 1940 – 28 November 1944	1,607
Overseas: Middle East and Ceylon	15 September 1940 (embarked) – 7 August 1942 (landed Melbourne)	692
Overseas: Papua	8 December 1942 (embarked) – 17 February 1944 (landed Brisbane)	437
Overseas total		1,129

The earlier booklet's 691 + 437 = 1,128 counted the first period exclusively. The official 1,129 is correct.

His medals

The medal card in his file is ticked for six awards and records an enquiry dated 15 March 1954 and a dispatch notation read as "Posted 8/4/54". The card is the direct evidence of the awards. His service fits each one comfortably:

Medal	Qualifying rule (Army)	Cyril's qualifying service
1939–45 Star	6 months (180 days) operational service	Western Desert and Tobruk, December 1940 – July 1941; Papua 1942–44
Africa Star	One day or more in North Africa operations	Egypt and Libya 1940–41
Pacific Star	Operational service in the Pacific theatre	Papua from 12 December 1942
Defence Medal	12 months non-operational service overseas, or 6 months in a non-operational area subject to air attack or closely threatened; sea passage to a non-operational area counts	Very probably Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon (July 1941 – March 1942) plus Ceylon (March – July 1942) and the voyages: roughly a year in all. The exact Army reckoning is not on file.
War Medal 1939–45	28 days full-time service	1,607 days
Australia Service Medal 1939–45	Originally 18 months full-time service (reduced to 30 days in 1996)	Qualified under the original 1949 rule; the 1996 change is irrelevant to him

Rats of Tobruk

"Rat of Tobruk" was the name the defenders adopted after enemy propaganda used it. It is a veteran identity and association, not an official medal. The Rats of Tobruk Association register lists Cyril by name and service number, with a note referring to 4 AGH in Tobruk.

Later life

Cyril died on 7 January 1977, aged 59, and was buried at Dudley Park Cemetery on 11 January. The Office of Australian War Graves card records him as a Craftsman in the Corps of Electrical and Mechanical Engineers. His widow, Mrs I.M. Phillips, was then living at Mile End, Adelaide. The Repatriation Department reference in the file is MX 5497.

Why the 1971 letter exists

Evans's letter of 8 February 1971 begins by saying that Cyril had asked him to record and verify these incidents, and it is addressed "To Whom It May Concern". A veteran seeking a signed statement from a comrade six years before his death suggests the letter was meant for an official purpose, most likely a repatriation or pension claim on file MX 5497. That is an inference, but it makes the repatriation file the most promising single source still unseen.

MAPS AND MOVEMENTS

Where the records place him

Most route lines in family histories show the movement of a unit or a ship, not a precise record of one man. Cyril's own file confirms selected embarkations, disembarkations, hospital admissions and postings; unit war diaries supply the wider route.

Middle East, 1940–42

The 2/2nd Army Field Workshops and No. 6 Recovery Section moved through Egypt and Libya (Fuka, Kilo 104, Bardia, Tobruk, Derna, Slonta, Barce, Maddalena, Mersa Matruh), then Tobruk under siege, Palestine (Barbara, Beit Jirja, Khassa), Transjordan (H4) and Lebanon (Ablah). His record confirms arrival in October 1940, the June 1941 hospital stay in Tobruk, the named Routine Orders of September–November 1941 and departure in March 1942. The windmill site at Tobruk remains unidentified.

Ceylon and Papua

The outward voyage to Ceylon and the return to Melbourne rest on the service record, Moran and the matching 16th Brigade shipping dates. In Papua the recorded destination is only "New Guinea"; Port Moresby is the strongest reconstruction from his hospital admissions and evacuation, and should be shown as a probable service area rather than a confirmed landing port.

Mapping convention

Solid statements are supported by Cyril's record or a named personal source. Unit routes and approximate sites are labelled as such. The Derna Road position is approximate, and the windmill is not plotted as a verified point.

TIMELINE

Service at a glance

Date	Event	Evidence
25 Jun 1940	Medical examination in Adelaide; fit Class I.	NAA B883 pp. 1, 4
6 Jul 1940	Enlists as Private SX8216; Group I Blacksmith.	NAA p. 5
9 Jul 1940	Reports to Recruit Reception Depot.	NAA p. 5
16 Jul 1940	Marches in to 2/2 Army Field Workshops.	NAA p. 5
11–19 Aug 1940	Pre-embarkation leave.	NAA p. 5
14–15 Sep 1940	Entrains for Melbourne; embarks, very probably on *Nieuw Holland*.	NAA pp. 5, 10; Moran
22 Sep 1940	Convoy US 5 sails from Fremantle (four Dutch liners, 4,262 troops).	Naval Historical Society
12 Oct 1940	Disembarks in Middle East (recorded as Kantara); to Helwan.	NAA p. 5; unit diary
Dec 1940	Unit to Amiriya and Fuka; No. 6 Rec Sec advance party at Kilo 104.	AWM52 14/2/2/2; Moran
3–5 Jan 1941	Bardia captured; Cyril's blacksmithing on damaged tanks.	AWM; Evans letter
21–22 Jan 1941	6th Division captures Tobruk, using kangaroo-marked Italian tanks.	AWM
Mar 1941	Mersa Matruh; 140 vehicle spring sets set up.	Evans letter; unit diary (432 jobs)
c. 5–11 Apr 1941	No. 6 Rec Sec to Tobruk; Derna Road position one mile west.	Moran; AWM52 14/2/1/4
10–11 Apr 1941	Siege of Tobruk begins.	AWM
14–17 Jun 1941	In 2/4 AGH, Tobruk; returns to unit.	NAA p. 5
17 Jun – early Jul 1941	Night evacuation by destroyer ("Stewart", probably HMAS *Stuart*); train to Alexandria strafed.	Evans letter; Sea Power Centre; dates bracketed by NAA and unit diary
11 Jul 1941	No. 6 Rec Sec marches in to Barbara, Palestine.	AWM52 14/2/2/6
Late Aug – Sep 1941	Section services 5th Indian Division at H4, Transjordan.	Unit diary; Moran
22 & 29 Sep 1941	Named in Khassa guard Routine Orders.	AWM52 14/2/2/7
29 Oct & 6 Nov 1941	Named in Ablah guard Routine Orders.	AWM52 14/2/2/8
12–27 Mar 1942	Embarks in Middle East; lands in Ceylon.	NAA p. 5; Moran
5 Apr 1942	Japanese air raid on Colombo.	General history
13 Jul – 7 Aug 1942	HMT *Ekma*, Ceylon to Melbourne (same dates as 16th Brigade units).	NAA pp. 5, 18
15 Sep 1942	To 6 Aust Div Ordnance Workshop, Greta NSW.	NAA p. 6; AWM52 14/2/2/9
3 Nov 1942	Entrains for Queensland.	NAA p. 6
1 Dec 1942	AEME formed; becomes Craftsman.	General history
8–12 Dec 1942	Townsville on *Duntroon*; lands in New Guinea 12 December.	NAA pp. 6, 18
12 Jul 1943	To 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops from 16 Bde Sec, 6 Div Workshop.	NAA p. 6
5–23 Sep 1943	128 AGH, Port Moresby (NYD); then NG Details Depot.	NAA p. 6
6 Sep 1943	Mother writes from Borrika for her badge; badge sent.	NAA p. 10
29 Jan 1944	Admitted 2/1 AGH, Bootless Bay.	NAA p. 6
1 Feb 1944	Regraded Group I Fitter ("Ins").	NAA pp. 5–6
13 Feb 1944	Embarks Port Moresby on hospital ship *Manunda*.	NAA p. 6
17–22 Feb 1944	Brisbane; ambulance train to 115 AGH Heidelberg; then 121 AGH Northfield. Essential hypertension.	NAA pp. 6, 18
8–10 Mar 1944	Medical board, Class B; SA L of C Area Details Depot.	NAA pp. 6–7
25 Mar 1944	Marries Irene May.	NAA pp. 1, 5
28 Apr 1944	Next of kin changed to wife, Borrika.	NAA p. 5

Date	Event	Evidence
26 Apr – 26 May 1944	SA L of C Area Workshops, AEME.	NAA p. 7
Jun – Sep 1944	7 Technical Maintenance Section; Linemen Mechanics Course No. 70.	NAA p. 7
2–18 Oct 1944	105 AMH, Adelaide; final board Class D, 17 October.	NAA pp. 8, 14
28 Nov 1944	Discharged at Wayville, medically unfit.	NAA pp. 8, 18, 21
Apr 1954	Six medals posted to Borrika (read as 8 April).	NAA p. 9
8 Feb 1971	Bert Evans writes his statement at Cyril's request.	VWMA transcript
7 Jan 1977	Dies, aged 59.	NAA pp. 19–20
11 Jan 1977	Buried at Dudley Park Cemetery.	NAA p. 20

What the trade and unit terms mean

Term	Explanation
Army Field Workshop (AFW)	A mobile repair organisation supporting a formation. The 2/2nd had a Main Shop and three Recovery Sections.
Recovery Section	A mobile element that retrieved, repaired and returned vehicles and equipment. No. 6 Recovery Section was raised in South Australia.
Group I Blacksmith / Fitter	Cyril's recorded skilled-trade grading. Group I was the highest of the Army's trade-pay groups; the exact rate should be cited from contemporary instructions if discussed.
Craftsman (Cfn)	The AEME title for a private soldier from December 1942. Not a promotion.
AAOC / AEME / RAEME	Australian Army Ordnance Corps; Australian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers (formed 1 December 1942); "Royal" added in 1948.
Ordnance / Brigade Workshop	Workshop units maintaining divisional and brigade equipment. The 6th Division workshop organisation was reorganised in 1942; later brigade workshops included 2/121.
No. 1 Group / No. 2 Group	Workshop sub-units, not the same as Cyril's Group I trade classification.
LAD / OFP	Light Aid Detachment (a small repair element attached to a fighting unit) / Ordnance Field Park (a mobile store of spares and replacement equipment).
AGH / AMH	Australian General Hospital / Australian Military Hospital. "2/" numbers were AIF hospitals raised for overseas service.
NYD	Not yet diagnosed: a provisional hospital entry.
X list	Administrative status for men temporarily away from their unit, often in hospital.
L of C Area	Lines of Communication Area: commands handling depots, hospitals and men in transit.
HMT	His Majesty's Transport (or Troopship): a merchant ship hired or requisitioned to carry troops.
Class B / Class D	Medical fitness grades. Cyril was Class B in March 1944 and Class D in October 1944, before medical discharge.
Female Relative Badge	A badge inscribed "To the Women of Australia", issued from 1940 to the nearest female relative of a member serving abroad, with a star for each relative serving. This is the "broach" Cyril's mother requested.

FURTHER RESEARCH

Questions still open

1. Obtain the repatriation file MX 5497

Now the highest priority. It may hold the claim that prompted the 1971 Evans letter, the original signed letter, and his later medical history. Ask the NAA or the Department of Veterans' Affairs; treat medical material sensitively.

2. Obtain the original Bert Evans letter

Ask Joan Soroka whether the carbon copy can be scanned, to confirm the destroyer name as written and whether the footnotes ("mid-July 1941") are Evans's or added later.

3. Identify the Tobruk evacuation vessel

Search the 2/2 AFW and 2/1 AFW diaries for late June – early July 1941 movement orders and embarkation returns, and check which destroyers ran Tobruk – Mersa Matruh on those nights.

4. The two sailing groups of 1940

DVA records a 2/2nd Field Workshops party leaving Melbourne on 13 August 1940 via Bombay. Confirm from the war diary which sections sailed then and which went in convoy US 5.

5. 16th/17th Brigade

The 13 July – 7 August shipping match points to the 16th Brigade group. The 6 Division Ordnance Workshop, 16 Brigade Section and 2/121 Brigade Workshops diaries, or a nominal roll, would settle it.

6. Locate "the windmill"

Compare the Derna Road position with contemporary Tobruk perimeter maps, Italian 1:50,000 "Tobruch" sheets, AWM map LIB52519 and the 2/1 AFW diaries.

7. Private E.O.J. Dunning MM

Find his recommendation (AWM28 series) and section. If he was in 6 Recovery Section, his citation may describe work Cyril shared.

8. "Australia (now)" in the 1943 letter

His mother wrote "Australia (now)" under his unit address while he was in Papua. Check whether this was a postal convention, a misunderstanding, or reflects something in his letters home.

9. Confirm the extra portrait

Ask the Virtual War Memorial contributor for the original print, any inscription on the back and the family provenance.

10. Verify Irene's maiden name

Order the 25 March 1944 marriage registration from SA Births, Deaths and Marriages, or find a marriage notice on Trove, before printing Dohnt or any other surname.

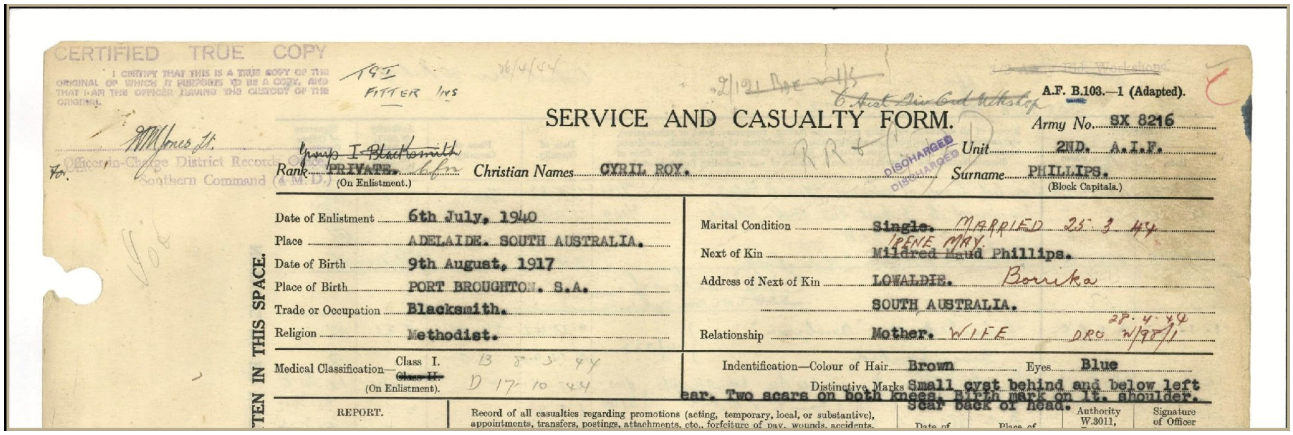
11. Family notices and burial details

Search Trove for the 1944 marriage and 1977 death notices, and ask Dudley Park Cemetery for the burial register and grave location.

Resolved since the last edition: the overseas-days arithmetic (inclusive counting; see chapter seven).

APPENDIX

Documents from Cyril's service file



SERVICE AND CASUALTY FORM. A.F. B.103.—1 (Adapted).

Army No. SX 8216 Unit 2ND. A.I.F.

Rank PRIVATE. (On Enlistment.) Christian Names CYRIL ROY. Surname PHILLIPS. (Block Capitals.)

Date of Enlistment 6th July, 1940 — Marital Condition Single. MARRIED 25.3.44

Place ADELAIDE. SOUTH AUSTRALIA. — Next of Kin IRENE MAY. Mildred Maud Phillips.

Date of Birth 9th August, 1917 — Address of Next of Kin LOWALDIE. Borrika SOUTH AUSTRALIA.

Place of Birth PORT BROUGHTON. S.A. — Relationship Mother. WIFE

Trade or Occupation Blacksmith.

Religion Methodist.

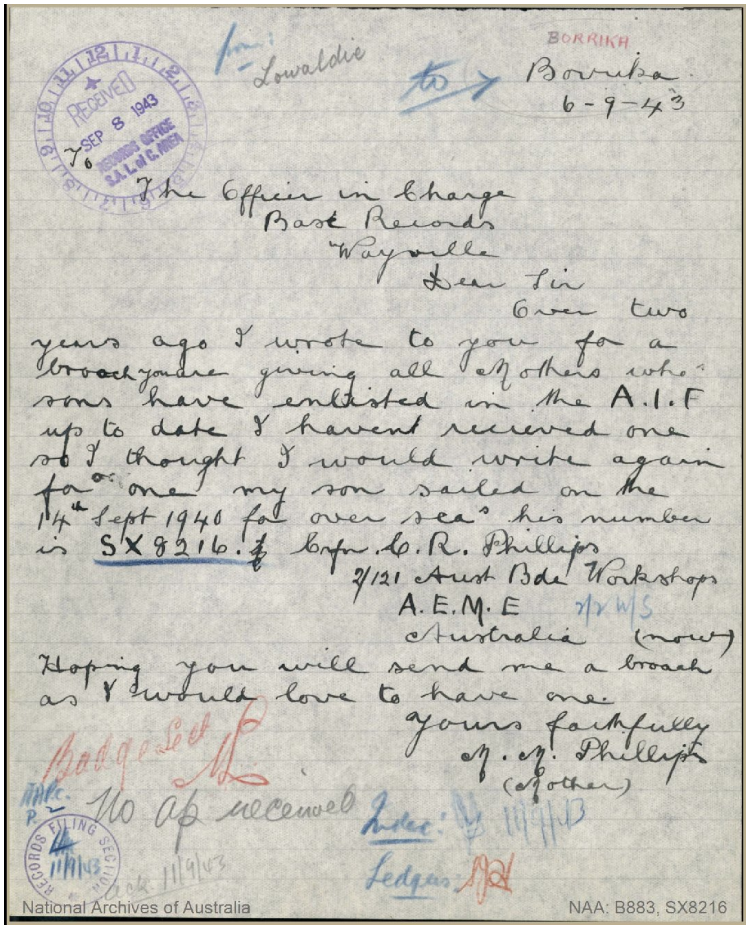
Medical Classification Class I. (On Enlistment). B 8.3.44 D 17.10.44

Identification—Colour of Hair Brown Eyes Blue

Distinctive Marks Small cyst behind and below left ear. Two scars on both knees. Birth mark on lt. shoulder. Scar back of head.

REPORT. Record of all casualties regarding promotions (acting, temporary, local, or substantive), appointments, transfers, postings, attachments, etc., forfeiture of pay, wounds, accidents. Date of Place of Authority W.3011. Signature of Officer

Service and Casualty Form (A.F. B.103), NAA B883, SX8216, p. 5. Note the amendments: rank to Cfn, MARRIED 25.3.44, next of kin to IRENE MAY Phillips (wife) at Borrika on 28.4.44, medical grades B (8.3.44) and D (17.10.44), and the full list of distinctive marks.



Borrika
6-9-43

The Officer in Charge
Base Records
Wayville

Dear Sir

Over two years ago I wrote to you for a broach you're giving all Mothers who's sons have enlisted in the A.I.F up to date I haven't recieved one so I thought I would write again for one my son sailed on the 14th Sept 1940 for over sea's his number is SX8216. Cfn. C.R. Phillips 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops A.E.M.E Australia (now)

Hoping you will send me a broach as I would love to have one.

Yours faithfully
M.M. Phillips
(Mother)

Badge Sent

No AF received

National Archives of Australia NAA: B883, SX8216

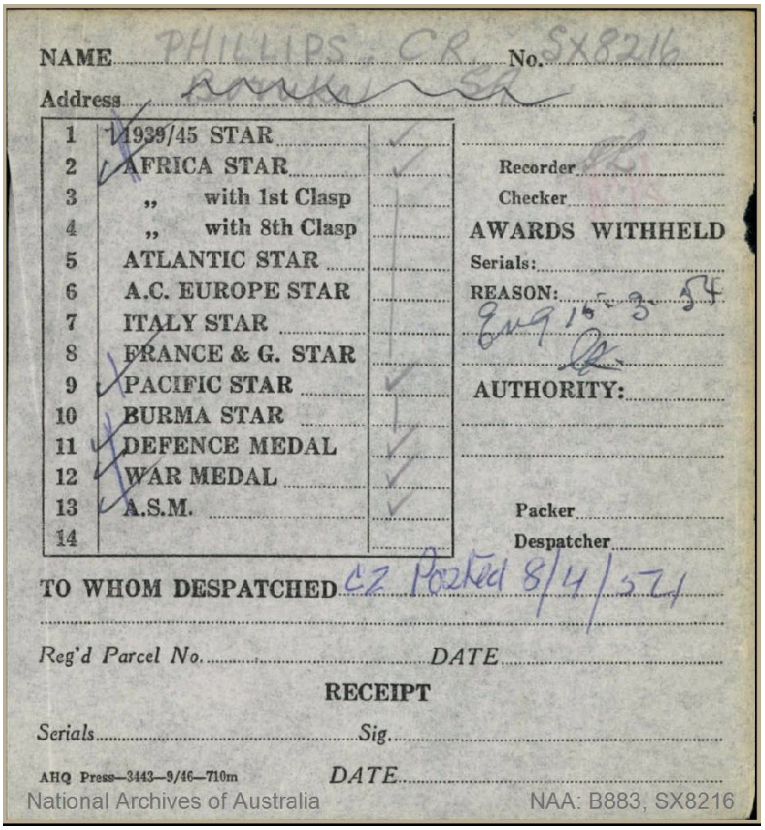
Mildred Phillips's letter from Borrika, 6 September 1943. NAA B883, SX8216, p. 10.

Transcription (original spelling kept)

Borrika, 6-9-43. To the Officer in Charge, Base Records, Wayville. Dear Sir, Over two years ago I wrote to you for a broach you're giving all Mothers who's sons have enlisted in the A.I.F. Up to date I haven't recieved one so I thought I would write again for one. My son sailed on the 14th Sept 1940 for over sea's; his number is SX8216 Cfn. C.R. Phillips, 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops, A.E.M.E., Australia (now). Hoping you will send me a broach as I would love to have one. Yours faithfully, M.M. Phillips (Mother).

Office annotations show it was received by the Records Office, SA L of C Area, on 8 September 1943, and marked "Badge sent", "No AF received" and filed on 11 September 1943. Her first request therefore dates from about mid-1941, and the badge was finally sent in September 1943.

The medal card and the witness account



NAME PHILLIPS. C.R. No. SX8216

Address

1	1939/45 STAR	✓
2	AFRICA STAR	✓
3	„ with 1st Clasp	
4	„ with 8th Clasp	
5	ATLANTIC STAR	
6	A.C. EUROPE STAR	
7	ITALY STAR	
8	FRANCE & G. STAR	
9	PACIFIC STAR	✓
10	BURMA STAR	✓
11	DEFENCE MEDAL	✓
12	WAR MEDAL	✓
13	A.S.M.	✓
14		

Recorder

Checker

AWARDS WITHHELD

Serials:

REASON: Enq 15-3-54

AUTHORITY:

Packer

Despatcher

TO WHOM DESPATCHED C2 Posted 8/4/54

Reg'd Parcel No. DATE

RECEIPT

Serials Sig.

AHQ Press—3443—9/46—710m DATE

National Archives of Australia NAA: B883, SX8216

Medal card, NAA B883, SX8216, p. 9. Six awards ticked; enquiry dated 15.3.54; dispatch read as "Posted 8/4/54".

The Evans letter belongs alongside these Army records, not in place of them. It is a different kind of evidence: what a comrade remembered about Cyril's actual work and conditions.

Evans wrote of the

> *"extremely long and sustained hours which Cyril Phillips (in his capacity as blacksmith) and others worked"*

to restore damaged tanks after Bardia. The full transcript is on Cyril's Virtual War Memorial Australia profile, submitted in May 2023 by Evans's daughter, Joan Soroka, who holds the carbon copy. Permission should be obtained before reproducing the complete letter in a public edition.

SOURCES

Where this account comes from

[1] National Archives of Australia, B883, SX8216, Phillips, Cyril Roy. Service record, 21 pages, item 6411180. The controlling source for enlistment, movements, medical entries, next of kin, medal card and discharge. Page references are to the digitised file. recordsearch.naa.gov.au

[2] Bert Evans, SX4626, letter "To Whom It May Concern", Glandore SA, 8 February 1971; transcript on Virtual War Memorial Australia, profile of Cyril Roy Phillips, submitted by Joan Soroka, 4 May 2023. vwma.org.au/explore/people/601041

[3] AWM52 14/2/2/2 to 14/2/2/9, 2/2 Army Field Workshops war diary, May 1940 – September 1942, including Routine Orders naming SX8216 Phillips in 1941.

[4] AWM52 14/2/1/4, 2/1 Army Field Workshops war diary, March–April 1941 (No. 6 Recovery Section on the Derna Road).

[5] AWM52 13/40/13/1, 2/121 Australian Brigade Ordnance Field Park, July 1943 – May 1944.

[6] G.H.S. Moran, *The Story of the 2/2 Army Field Workshops*, Outlook Press, Melbourne, 1964 (AWM LIB11198).

[7] Naval Historical Society of Australia, "Australian Naval History on 22 September 1940" (convoy US 5). navyhistory.au/22-september-1940

[8] Department of Veterans' Affairs, CLIK order of battle, Army (2/2nd Field Workshops; 16th and 17th Brigade unit movements, 1942). clik.dva.gov.au

[9] Sea Power Centre – Australia, "HMAS Stuart (I)". seapower.navy.gov.au/history/units/hmas-stuart-i

[10] Australian War Memorial, "Bardia or Bust!" (2021) and unit page, 6th Australian Division Cavalry Regiment (U54268); Australian War Memorial London, "Tobruk: the battle in brief". awm.gov.au; awmlondon.gov.au

[11] Australian War Memorial, honours record, Ernest Oswald James Dunning, SX9731, Military Medal (R1508698).

[12] Unit histories from G.R. McKenzie-Smith, *The Unit Guide: The Australian Army 1939–1945* (2018), as summarised by the City of Armadale "Our Contribution" wiki: 2/2nd Australian Infantry Troops Workshop; 128th, 121st and 2/1st Australian General Hospitals. birtwistlewiki.com.au

[13] Anzacs of Greece virtual memorial, 2/1st Australian Infantry Battalion (Ceylon 26 March – 13 July 1942; Melbourne 7 August 1942); Wikipedia, 2/5th Battalion (Athlone Castle, Melbourne 4 August 1942).

[14] Australian War Memorial, "Female Relative Badge" and 1940 badge conditions; Museums Victoria collection notes.

[15] Department of Defence, Defence Medal, 1939–45 Star and Australia Service Medal 1939–45 conditions; Defence Honours and Awards Appeals Tribunal decisions citing the 1948 Dedman paper and the 1996 ASM amendment. defence.gov.au; defence-honours-tribunal.gov.au

[16] Rats of Tobruk Association, Australian Army register, 31 August 2025. ratsoftobruktribute.com

[17] Health Museum SA, "Morris Hospital and the Australian Army General Hospital" (Northfield). healthmuseumsa.org.au

[18] Australian War Memorial photographs 004227, P01522.003, 006532, 128987, 021687, 075198 and 062135. Check each catalogue entry for rights before republication.

Evidence ratings

The NAA service file and contemporary AWM war diaries are primary documentary sources, very reliable for what they record. Evans's letter is a named first-hand account written 30 years later: high value, subject to memory limits. Moran's 1964 history is a specialist account checked against the diaries where possible. Official AWM, Navy, DVA and Defence pages give campaign and award context. Community memorial and association records are corroboration, not substitutes for original records.

EDITORIAL RECORD

What changed in this fact-checked edition

Section	Earlier text	Correction or addition and basis
Tobruk	"the 9th Australian Division took over the Tobruk garrison in March 1941"	Corrected: in March the 9th relieved the 6th in Cyrenaica; it withdrew into Tobruk on 9 April [10].
Tobruk evacuation	"mid-July"; Stuart's final run 25–26 July cited as a reason for doubt	Window narrowed to 17 June – early July from NAA and diary dates; this fits Stuart's 24 runs in June–July. Landing at Mersa Matruh suggested by the rail journey [1][3][9].
Overseas days	"1,129 vs 691 + 437 = 1,128: omit the breakdown"	Resolved: inclusive counting gives 692 + 437 = 1,129 exactly; total 1,607 also checks [1].
Voyage	Convoy US 5 named without detail	Added: Fremantle 22 Sep 1940, four Dutch liners, 4,262 troops, HMAS Canberra; second unit echelon via Bombay noted [7][8].
Ceylon	16th/17th Brigade discrepancy left open	Cyril's 13 Jul – 7 Aug voyage matches 16th Brigade units; 17th Brigade units landed 4 Aug [8][13].
Bardia	Tanks restored "for the first assault on Tobruk"	Linked to the kangaroo-marked Italian tanks of the 6th Division Cavalry; Tobruk captured 21–22 Jan 1941 [10].
Wife	"He married Irene May"	Clarified that Irene May are her given names; next of kin changed 28 Apr 1944 [1].
Identifying marks	Three marks listed	"Scar back of head" added from the form [1].
Mother's badge	"the badge issued to mothers whose sons had enlisted"	Named as the Female Relative Badge; annotation shows "Badge sent" Sept 1943; letter transcribed [1][14].
Rank	Private / Craftsman unexplained	Craftsman explained as AEME equivalent of private from 1 Dec 1942.
Medals	ASM 1996 30-day rule; Defence Medal basis "should be checked"	Cyril met the original 18-month ASM rule; likely Defence Medal basis set out [15].
Hospitals	128 AGH, 2/1 AGH, 121 AGH unverified	All three verified at the stated places and dates [12][17].
Evans letter	Testimony only	Added: Cyril requested it; route names (Derna, Slonta, Barce, Maddalena); "nearly four months" vs about three; Iraq "insurrection" timing [2].
Unit context	—	Added Pte E.O.J. Dunning MM, 2/2 Field Workshops [11].
Papua	Chapter titled "New Guinea"	Port Moresby was in the Territory of Papua; 16th Brigade's withdrawal in January 1943 added.
Layout and text	Overlapping text boxes (pp. 6, 11); "February?March", "Buna?Gona"; "R&I;"; references [7] and [9] missing; editor's notes to self in the text	Re-typeset; encoding errors fixed; references renumbered and completed; editorial asides removed or moved here.